

LIBERTY CYBER THREAT INTELLIGENCE

THE ALAMO THREAT BRIEF™

OPEN SOURCE INTELLIGENCE

ISSUE	ATB-2026-26
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DOMINANT JUDGMENT	WATER-SECTOR REMEDIATION LAUNCHES, IRAN WAR REFLARES

Executive decision intelligence for Texas critical infrastructure.

Executive Warning: Texas water-sector cybersecurity moved this week from standing warning to organized remediation. On 31 August 2026, Governor Abbott and White House National Cyber Director Sean Cairncross launched Project Watershed 250, a six-month pilot pairing Texas Cyber Command with EPA, CISA, and twelve private-sector technology and cybersecurity firms to find and fix cyber exposure at Texas water and wastewater utilities — at no cost to participating operators. The pilot arrives roughly five weeks after CISA and the FBI warned of a “significant escalation” in attacks against internet-exposed water-treatment controllers across at least seven states, an unattributed campaign that degraded operator control and forced manual operations at multiple utilities. Separately, renewed direct combat between the United States and Iran and an intensifying Russian hybrid campaign in Europe worsened the geopolitical backdrop this week, but neither has produced a confirmed new cyber indicator against Texas or comparable U.S. infrastructure — an absence Liberty CTI treats as analytically meaningful, not reassuring. The decision risk for executives: any organization whose operations, employees, or facilities depend on a local water utility, and who has not yet asked that utility about its cyber exposure, is behind — regardless of sector.

Board Implications This Week — Ask

Do we know which water utility serves each of our critical facilities by name, and has that utility told us — in writing — whether it has internet-facing OT exposure or is participating in Project Watershed 250?

Board Implications This Week — Direct

Direct facilities/continuity leadership to map water-supplier dependencies for every critical site this week, not as a future project.

Board Implications This Week — Document

Record the water-dependency map and the date/owner of the supplier inquiry in board or risk-committee minutes — this is the artifact that proves the question was actually asked.

Board Implications This Week — Rehearse

Add a named “loss of water pressure or service” scenario to the next continuity exercise, with a decision owner for manual-operation fallback identified in advance.

CENTERPIECE ANALYSIS

It is a **confirmed fact** that on 31 August 2026, Texas Governor Greg Abbott and White House National Cyber Director Sean Cairncross launched Project Watershed 250 at an event in San Antonio, pairing Texas Cyber Command with EPA and CISA as federal partners and a roster of private-sector firms — reported by trade press to include Microsoft, Google Cloud, Amazon Web Services, Palo Alto Networks, Fortinet, Cloudflare, Zscaler, Forescout, Dragos, Parsons, Reflection AI, and Abnormal AI — to provide free vulnerability assessment, red-teaming, and remediation support to Texas water and wastewater utilities over six months. It is separately a **confirmed fact** that on 30 July 2026, CISA and the FBI issued a joint public service announcement (Alert I-073026-PSA) describing a “significant escalation” in attacks against internet-exposed programmable logic controllers (PLCs) at water utilities in at least seven states since 27 July, in which malicious actors changed device passwords and IP addresses, causing loss of monitoring and control, boil-water notices, and forced manual operations at multiple sites. That PSA does not attribute the activity to a specific actor.

Liberty CTI assesses with **HIGH confidence** that Project Watershed 250 represents a genuine shift from warning to mitigation, not a symbolic announcement: it pairs a named federal-state-industry mechanism with a demonstrated, still-recent threat, and it is the first dedicated remediation pipeline Texas has stood up for this specific exposure class. Liberty CTI notes, per contemporaneous reporting, that the White House has stated Project Watershed 250 had been in development since 2025 and was not launched specifically in response to the July attacks — a distinction worth preserving rather than collapsing into a simpler cause-and-effect narrative, even though the timing convergence is still analytically relevant to how the program will be read publicly. Liberty CTI explicitly does **not rate confidence** on how much actual exposure has been reduced or how quickly the pilot will reach Texas’s more than 7,400 public water systems and 3,000-plus wastewater facilities, most of them small operators with limited OT security maturity — that is a separate, currently unanswerable question, and treating “the pilot launched” as equivalent to “risk went down” would overstate this week’s evidence.

Bottom line: Executives should not wait for their water provider to volunteer this information. Ask this week whether your water supplier knows its internet-facing OT exposure and whether it is participating in Project Watershed 250.

Section I

Key Judgments

KJ-1

It is a **confirmed fact, at HIGH confidence**, that Texas water-sector risk moved from warning to an organized mitigation *mechanism* this week via the 31 August launch of Project Watershed 250. Liberty CTI is explicit that this confidence rating covers the launch only. **HIGH CONFIDENCE (LAUNCH) — UNRATED**

(REMEDATION PACE)

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: gov.texas.gov press release, 31 August 2026; Axios San Antonio, 2 September 2026; CyberScoop reporting on participating vendors. Primary uncertainty: remediation pace and reach across thousands of mostly small Texas water and wastewater operators are unknown and are not rated by this judgment.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Do not treat the pilot’s launch as evidence that your own water supplier’s exposure has been resolved — confirm its status directly.

KJ-2

It is a **confirmed fact** that direct combat between U.S. and Iranian forces resumed on 1 September 2026 after a nearly month-long pause: CENTCOM struck IRGC air-defense, radar, maritime, mine-laying, and communications targets; Iran fired ballistic missiles at a U.S. carrier and destroyer (evaded, per U.S. officials, with damage claims from Iran that remain unconfirmed); a Saudi tanker was struck with two Filipino crew killed; and on 4 September, Treasury designated Golden Global Bank and two Turkish subsidiaries under Executive Order 13902, while the U.S. and three allies moved to refer Iran to the UN Security Council for the first time in twenty years. **HIGH CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: centcom.mil, 1 September 2026; home.treasury.gov, 4 September 2026.

Primary uncertainty: Iran's claim of damage to the U.S. carrier/destroyer is unconfirmed by any independent source as of this issue.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Treat this as an active war-risk period for Gulf-adjacent shipping, fuel costs, and Iran-linked cyber posture — not background noise to file away.

KJ-3

Liberty CTI assesses it is **likely (60–70%)** that this reversal — from the diplomatic opening ATB-2026-25 described to direct combat between U.S. and Iranian forces within a single week — raises, rather than lowers, the near-term probability of Iran-linked cyber or OT-focused retaliation reaching U.S. critical infrastructure, including Texas energy, financial, and water-sector targets, over the next one to four weeks. **MODERATE CONFIDENCE**

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: pattern analysis drawing on this week's confirmed kinetic and sanctions escalation (KJ-2); not tied to any specific new cyber indicator. Primary uncertainty: no Iran-attributed intrusion against a Texas target has been identified as of this issue, and prior episodes of U.S.-Iran kinetic escalation have not always produced a corresponding near-term cyber campaign against U.S. targets.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: Treat any Iran-linked PLC or OT indicator discovered in the coming weeks as more significant than it would have been during the prior month's relative lull, and re-run OFAC screening against the 4 September Golden Global Bank designation.

KJ-4

Liberty CTI assesses with **MODERATE confidence** that Russia's hybrid campaign in Europe remains relevant strategic context but does not currently establish a new cyber threat trajectory for Texas.

MODERATE CONFIDENCE

Source basis / uncertainty: Source basis: European government reporting on sustained sabotage, drone, disinformation, and cyber activity attributed to Russia. Primary uncertainty: whether Russia broadens the campaign's geographic scope toward U.S. or Texas targets is unresolved.

Decision implication: Decision Implication: No new action required this week beyond standing edge/router hardening already in place; continue monitoring rather than escalating posture.

Section II

What Changed This Week

Project Watershed 250 Launches, Anchored to a Live Threat Rather Than a Hypothetical One

Governor Abbott and National Cyber Director Sean Cairncross launched Project Watershed 250 on **31 August 2026** at an event in San Antonio, describing a six-month pilot connecting Texas water and wastewater utilities with federal, state, and private-sector cyber defense resources at no cost. Texas Cyber Command, led by Vice Admiral (Ret.) TJ White, will coordinate implementation with EPA and CISA as federal partners; trade press (CyberScoop) identified twelve participating companies including Microsoft, Google Cloud, Amazon Web Services, Palo Alto Networks, Fortinet, Cloudflare, Zscaler, Forescout, Dragos, Parsons, Reflection AI, and Abnormal AI, providing red-teaming, vulnerability assessment, remediation, and AI-enabled cyber defense tools. Per contemporaneous reporting cited by Route Fifty and Hoodline, the White House stated the program had been in development since 2025 and was not launched specifically in response to the July attacks described below — a nuance Liberty CTI preserves rather than assuming a direct causal link, even as the timing convergence remains relevant to public and executive perception of the program.

The Threat the Pilot Responds To: A Documented, Unattributed Multi-State PLC Intrusion Campaign

On **30 July 2026**, CISA and the FBI issued a joint public service announcement (Alert I-073026-PSA) warning of a “significant escalation” in cyberattacks targeting internet-exposed programmable logic controllers in the Water and Wastewater Systems sector. Since 27 July, utilities in at least seven states — including a wave affecting more than 30 community water systems in Minnesota and additional systems in Michigan — reported unauthorized access to internet-facing Rockwell Automation, Siemens, and Schneider Electric equipment, in which actors changed default passwords and device IP addresses, causing loss of monitoring and control, boil-water notices, and sustained manual operations at some sites. **The PSA does not attribute this campaign to a specific actor.** This is distinct from — though it echoes the same targeting pattern as — the previously established, Iran-affiliated PLC exploitation baseline documented in standing joint advisory AA26-097A (first published 7 April 2026, updated 22 July 2026), which does attribute activity to the IRGC-linked group CyberAv3ngers. Liberty CTI treats these as two related but analytically separate threads: a confirmed, attributed standing baseline, and a newer, unattributed campaign that is the direct proximate driver of this week’s Watershed 250 launch.

Direct U.S.-Iran Combat Resumes After Nearly a Month, Ending the Prior Diplomatic Signal

On **1 September 2026**, CENTCOM confirmed it had struck IRGC air-defense, radar, maritime, mine-laying, and communications targets in Iran, citing recent IRGC attacks on Gulf shipping and American forces — the first acknowledged U.S. strike wave since the roughly month-long pause ATB-2026-25 tracked. Iranian forces subsequently fired ballistic missiles at a U.S. aircraft carrier and a guided-missile destroyer; U.S. officials say the missiles were evaded with no personnel harmed, while Iran has publicly claimed damage that no independent source has confirmed as of this issue. A Saudi-flagged tanker was struck in the strait on 31 August, killing two Filipino crew members, and both sides disabled additional tankers through early September under a mutual “tanker for tanker” posture. On **4 September**, Treasury designated Golden Global Bank and two Turkish subsidiaries under Executive Order 13902 for allegedly facilitating IRGC-Qods Force transactions, and the United States, United Kingdom, France, and Germany drafted an IAEA Board resolution to refer Iran to the UN Security Council for the first time in twenty years, with a vote expected the week of 7–11 September. Liberty CTI identified no Iran-linked cyber campaign, TTP shift, or targeting change against Texas or comparable U.S. infrastructure in the days since — a negative but decision-relevant finding, addressed at KJ-3.

Russia's European Hybrid Campaign Continues; No New Texas-Facing Trajectory Established

European governments continue to describe an active Russian campaign combining sabotage, drone incursions, disinformation, and cyber operations below the threshold of open conflict. This reinforces Liberty CTI's standing Russia baseline — persistent access to Western edge and communications infrastructure, demonstrated destructive capability against European energy systems — but this week's reporting does not indicate broadened Russian targeting of U.S. or Texas infrastructure.

China's QTFY Disclosure Remains Standing Context

The 26 August DOJ/FBI/NSA disclosure of the QTFY access-broker network, ATB-2026-25's centerpiece, falls outside this week's coverage window and is carried forward as background only. No Texas victim has been publicly named as of this issue.

Section III

Geopolitical Driver

The renewed U.S.-Iran confrontation around the Strait of Hormuz is this week's clearest geopolitical trigger — not because it produced new cyber activity, but because it raises the warning value of any indicator that follows. Any Iran-linked PLC reconnaissance, hack-and-leak operation, DDoS campaign, or targeting of U.S. energy, water, maritime, or municipal entities discovered in the coming weeks should be read as more significant than it would have been during the prior month's relative lull. The IAEA Board vote on referring Iran to the UN Security Council, expected the week of 7–11 September, is the next event most likely to move that needle further. Russia's hybrid campaign in Europe demonstrates continued willingness to operate below the threshold of open conflict, sustaining rather than escalating existing risk to Western infrastructure. Neither driver, on this week's evidence, has yet translated into changed adversary cyber behavior against Texas.

CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING

Continuum assessment: Texas remains in **competition**, with the geopolitical backdrop worsened but not yet accompanied by a confirmed cyber escalation against a Texas target. **No Flash Warning threshold was met this week.** The organized, defensive posture represented by Project Watershed 250 is this week's most consequential Texas-specific development — a mitigation story, not an attack story.

Section IV

Why This Matters to Texas

Water is the least-monitored dependency in Texas critical infrastructure relative to its downstream consequence. Executives who track their power supplier's cyber posture closely often cannot name their water supplier's. Project Watershed 250 addresses that gap at the state-and-pilot level; it does not, by itself, tell any individual organization whether its own water dependency is covered. That gap is this week's decision-relevant fact for every Texas sector, not just the water utilities themselves.

Cross-Sector Cascade Assessment

Energy Cooling Water / Generation Dependency	What changed: Project Watershed 250 launched to remediate water-sector OT exposure documented since late July; no new energy-specific cyber development occurred this week. Why it matters locally: Power generation and grid operations depend on water for cooling and process functions, making a degraded water utility a potential single point of failure upstream of energy reliability — not merely a municipal-services problem. Cascade risk: Energy-sector operators should confirm which water utilities their generation and transmission assets depend on and whether those utilities have unresolved internet-facing OT exposure or are enrolled in Watershed 250.
Financial Steady-State Sanctions Discipline	What changed: Treasury designated Golden Global Bank and two Turkish subsidiaries under Executive Order 13902 on 4 September for allegedly facilitating IRGC-Qods Force transactions, amid the broader Iran war reflare (KJ-2). Why it matters locally: Texas financial institutions and energy financiers with any Turkish, Gulf, or Iran-adjacent correspondent relationship now face a faster-moving sanctions environment than a month ago. Cascade risk: Confirm OFAC screening is current against the 4 September designation this week; treat KJ-3's rising retaliation-risk judgment as reason to keep this current rather than deferring to the next board cycle.
Healthcare / DIB / AI Water-Dependent, Water-Blind Facilities	What changed: Project Watershed 250 launched in direct response to a documented water-OT threat; no Watershed 250 participant list specific to individual utilities has been published as of this issue. Why it matters locally: Hospitals, defense installations, and AI data centers are all water-dependent for treatment, cooling, and life-safety functions, and few track their water supplier's cyber posture the way they track their power supplier's. Texas's concentration of AI data centers — already under separate regulatory and grid-capacity scrutiny following the Texas AG's AI data-center plan and ERCOT's large-load interconnection review flagged in ATB-2026-25 — adds a resource-competition dimension: cooling-water demand and cyber exposure are converging risk factors for the same facilities. Cascade risk: A sustained water-service disruption at a facility supporting a hospital, defense contractor, or large data center is a direct operational continuity risk, not a secondary one.

Section V

Indicators & Warnings — PIR Watch, 1 to 4 Weeks

PIR 5 / I&W 1 Confirmed actor attribution for the July water-PLC campaign [→ Unclear]

- Watch for FBI, EPA, or CISA to name an actor for the 27 July–onward campaign; the current PSA remains unattributed, separate from the standing Iran-affiliated AA26-097A baseline.
- Tied to: PIR 5, strategic vulnerability exposure indicators.

PIR 1 / I&W 2 Iran-linked PLC reconnaissance or intrusion against U.S. energy, water, or maritime systems [↑ Rising]

- Watch especially for any indicator temporally tied to the renewed Hormuz strikes or the IAEA Board vote — this is the specific outcome KJ-3 anticipates but has not yet confirmed.
- Tied to: PIR 1, adversary intent and targeting indicators.

PIR 6 / I&W 3 Public identification of specific Texas utilities in the Watershed 250 pilot, or a first remediation milestone [→ *Unclear*]

→ Watch for Texas Cyber Command or ONCD to name participating utilities or report an initial vulnerability-reduction figure, which would allow Liberty CTI to move KJ-1's remediation-pace question from unrated to an actual assessment.

→ Tied to: PIR 6, executive decision-relevant warning indicators.

PIR 1 / I&W 4 New GRU-linked reconnaissance or edge/router compromise affecting U.S. energy, telecom, or defense-industrial targets [→ *Sustained*]

→ Watch for any broadening of Russia's European hybrid campaign toward U.S. infrastructure, which would move KJ-3 from moderate confidence toward an active Texas-facing concern.

→ Tied to: PIR 1, geopolitical-cyber acceleration indicators.

PIR 2 / I&W 5 Additional water-sector operational anomalies at any U.S. utility, particularly in Texas [↑ *Rising*]

→ Watch for pressure or pumping irregularities, operator lockout, or unexplained PLC configuration changes at any utility — a Texas-specific incident would be this thread's most significant possible escalation.

→ Tied to: PIR 2, cross-sector cascading risk indicators.

Section VI

Governance Implication Block

Decision at risk	Whether the organization's water-supplier cyber exposure — and its own downstream continuity risk — is actually owned and being remediated, rather than assumed to be someone else's problem.
Owner	Utility GM or city manager for water and wastewater providers. COO, CISO, or emergency management lead for water-dependent organizations — hospitals, data centers, manufacturers, defense sites, and energy facilities.
Consequence of delay	Loss of operator control at the utility level, undetected manipulation of treatment or pumping systems, and cascading disruption into hospitals, data centers, energy facilities, and manufacturing that assumed water supply was a given rather than a monitored dependency.
Action this week	Identify water-supplier dependencies for critical facilities by name; request written confirmation of the supplier's internet-facing OT exposure status and Project Watershed 250 participation; add water-service loss to the next continuity exercise.
Record to preserve	Water-dependency map by facility, supplier correspondence on cyber posture, and the date and named owner of record for this week's inquiry.

Section VII

Actions This Week

CRITICAL INTELLIGENCE WARNING

Water and wastewater utility CISOs/OT leads: Audit internet-facing PLC exposure this week; eliminate default or weak credentials; confirm remote-access logging is functioning, not just configured.

Executives at water-dependent facilities: Identify primary and backup water suppliers by name — if this isn't already documented, check the facility's water utility bill or call the city/county public works line to confirm whether service comes from a municipal utility, a private water authority, or an on-site well. Request written confirmation of cyber posture and Watershed 250 status; do not accept silence as an answer.

Emergency management/continuity leads: Add a named "loss of water pressure or service" scenario to the next continuity exercise, with an assigned owner and a decision on manual-operation fallback.

Finance/compliance leaders: Confirm OFAC screening is current against the 4 September Golden Global Bank designation (Executive Order 13902); no further escalation required this week beyond that check.

Section VIII

Prior Judgment Tracker

Prior judgment	ATB-2026-25 (29 August 2026) assessed, at moderate confidence, that the pairing of harder sanctions (Operation Economic Outcast) with a genuine diplomatic opening (Pakistani/Qatari mediation, Iran's reported draft reopening conditions) modestly lowered the near-term likelihood of Iran-attributed cyber escalation against Texas targets, while continuing to build sanctions pressure.
Current status	Reversed, not merely moderated. Direct U.S.-Iran combat resumed 1 September for the first time in nearly a month (KJ-2); the diplomatic channel produced no reopening and instead a UN Security Council referral; this issue's KJ-3 replaces ATB-2026-25's de-escalation judgment with a 60–70% likely re-escalation judgment.
What changed	This issue's dominant development is Project Watershed 250 (KJ-1), analytically distinct from the Iran thread: it addresses a documented but unattributed water-OT campaign, not a confirmed Iran-attributed one. The Iran war reflare (KJ-2/KJ-3) is this week's second major, separately tracked development. The two threads should not be conflated even though both concern critical-infrastructure OT.
Accuracy line	0 of 1 forecast elements confirmed as stated for ATB-2026-25's de-escalation judgment — it did not hold; superseded this issue by KJ-3. KJ-3's own forecast window (1–4 weeks from 1 September) is newly opened and unresolved; next review due no later than ATB-2026-27.
Next indicator	A confirmed Iran-attributed intrusion against a Texas target, the IAEA Board vote outcome, or actor attribution for the July water-PLC campaign would each move this tracker's judgments in the next issue.

Section IX — Sourcing

Open Source Basis

PRIMARY SOURCES — ATB-2026-26 — COVERAGE WEEK 30 AUGUST–5 SEPTEMBER 2026

GOVERNMENT / STATE

Office of the Texas Governor — Governor Abbott, National Cyber Director Launch Project Watershed 250 To Defend Texas Water Supply

gov.texas.gov, 31 August 2026

Primary basis for the Dominant Judgment, KJ-1, and Section II.

GOVERNMENT / CYBERSECURITY

CISA — CISA Urges Water and Wastewater Systems Sector to Protect OT Against Activity Targeting PLCs

cisa.gov, 30 July 2026

Primary basis for the underlying threat described in the Dominant Judgment and Section II; confirms the campaign is unattributed.

GOVERNMENT / MULTI-AGENCY

CISA/FBI/NSA/EPA/DOE/CNMF/Treasury — Joint Cybersecurity Advisory AA26-097A: Iranian-Affiliated Cyber Actors Exploit Programmable Logic Controllers Across US Critical Infrastructure

media.defense.gov, originally 7 April 2026, updated 22 July 2026

Standing Iran-affiliated OT exploitation baseline, cited in Section II and KJ-2 to distinguish attributed from unattributed activity.

GOVERNMENT / DEFENSE

U.S. Central Command — CENTCOM Completes Strikes on IRGC Targets in Iran

centcom.mil, 1 September 2026

Primary basis for KJ-2 and Section II's Iran reflare item.

GOVERNMENT / REGULATORY

U.S. Department of the Treasury — Treasury Severs Iranian Regime's Financial Lifelines in Türkiye

home.treasury.gov, 4 September 2026

Primary basis for KJ-2 and the Finance cross-sector implication.

NEWS / LOCAL

Axios San Antonio — San Antonio launch kicks off Texas water cybersecurity pilot

axios.com, 2 September 2026

Cited for federal-partner and private-sector participant detail corroborating the gov.texas.gov release.

TRADE PRESS / STATE-LEVEL POLICY

Route Fifty and Hoodline — White House launches water cybersecurity pilot in Texas; San Antonio becomes test bed

route-fifty.com and hoodline.com, 31 Aug–1 Sept 2026

Cited for the White House's stated position that the pilot was not launched specifically in response to the July attacks.

CYBERSECURITY TRADE PRESS

CyberScoop (via secondary aggregation) — Texas Cyber Command and White House launch Project Watershed 250

cinchops.com summarizing CyberScoop reporting, 5 September 2026

Cited only for the twelve-vendor participant list; not independently confirmed against a CyberScoop direct fetch this cycle.

INDUSTRY / TECHNICAL ANALYSIS

Tenable and Foley Hoag — Coordinated cyberattack on Minnesota water utilities; Rising cyberattacks on U.S. water infrastructure

tenable.com and foleyhoag.com, August 2026

Cited for technical detail on the July campaign and to confirm the PSA does not attribute the activity to a specific actor, distinguishing it from AA26-097A.

TORCH FUSION CYCLE

WHAT: The week of 30 August–5 September 2026 is defined by the 31 August launch of Project Watershed 250, a six-month federal-state-industry pilot to remediate Texas water-sector cyber exposure documented since a 30 July CISA/FBI advisory, against a backdrop of unresolved U.S.-Iran hostilities and continuing Russian hybrid activity in Europe, neither of which produced a new confirmed cyber indicator this week. **WHO:** Texas Cyber Command, the White House Office of the National Cyber Director, EPA, and CISA defined this week's evidence base, alongside twelve private-sector partners. **WHY:** This brief's discipline of separating confirmed facts from analytic judgment is precisely what let it treat "the pilot launched" and "risk was reduced" as two different claims, and to openly reverse ATB-2026-25's Iran de-escalation judgment now that the evidence underneath it changed — exactly the correction the Prior Judgment Tracker exists to catch and publish, not bury. **WHAT NEXT:** Watch for actor attribution on the July water-PLC campaign, the IAEA Board vote outcome, any Iran-attributed intrusion against a Texas target, and the first public report on Watershed 250's remediation results. *An assessment that cannot be wrong in public is not an assessment. It is a press release.*

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